

Shabbos Nachamu - Parshas Vaeschanan is a beloved parsha. It has two עליות for which people bid a lot of money: שמע ישראל and עשרת הדברות. One of the most famous, if not the most famous, differences between Yisro and Vaeschanan is what we say every Friday night in Lecha Dodi: שמור וזכור בדבור אחד. Only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time. Nobody else can. People can talk out of both sides of their mouth, להבדיל, but only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time.

That brings us to an interesting story, one of my favorites, brought down in Rabbi Peretz Steinberg's beautiful sefer on חומש called ספר פרי עץ חיים in the name of R' Yaakov Kamenetsky on the pasuk (5:12) שמור וזכור. R' Yaakov once went into a חדר in ירושלים where there were little kids, and he asked them "In Lecha Dodi it says שמור וזכור בדבור אחד. But what was actually written on the לוחות, did it say שמור or זכור?" All the little קינדערלאך raised their hands. He went through the whole room, and they all said "It said זכור on the לוחות" which is what you see in every shul.

One little fellow in the back said, "It said שמור on the לוחות." R' Yaakov asked him "How do you know that?" The boy replied "That's what it says in the סידור." "Where?" The boy answered "In Shabbos shachris: ישמח משה במתנת חלקו כי עבד נאמן קראת לו כליל תפארת בראשו נתת בעמך לפניה על הר סיני ושני לחות אבנים: שמירת שבת זכירת שבת. R' Yaakov said, "This boy is going to grow up to be a big חכם."

What are we saying when we say שמור and זכור? What is the message? What is the concept? What are we trying to learn from this? Anything that is precious to us has to be guarded. We constantly think about the things that are precious to us - not our possessions, not our גשמיות, but our רוחניות: our family, our טייערע, our spouses, our parents. These are the precious things. Our תורה and our מצוות. Shabbos is one of our most prized possessions of all. We have to guard it. We have to keep it. We have to take care of it. We have to watch and look for better and newer ways to be more careful with Shabbos.

The more that we learn הלכות שבת, the more we learn how to do it right. Just a tiny example: I used to love to put scallions into my chicken soup on Friday night. Rabbi Oelbaum once told me that I'm not allowed to do that, because scallions are easily cooked - it's called קלי הבישול - and even though we normally say that there's no בישול in a כלי שלישי, with foods that are קלי הבישול, like scallions, we say there can be בישול even in a כלי שלישי. So I learned something; now I don't do it, and I'm being שומר שבת even more than I did before.

No matter what it is, every single little thing that we do adds up. The things we think are little down here are very big up there. And some of the things that the world thinks are big down here are nothing up there, as we well know. Let us all strive to do all of our שמירת המצוות better, and we will indeed be מקיים. שמור וזכור בדיבור אחד.

